

mail of the week

rnment at the Centre. And interestingly, every leader of the front claims to be the only suitable prime ministerial candidate. The Third Front can hardly come in the front, and shall continue to remain in oblivion.

P.K. SRIVASTAVA, on e-mail

If H.D. Deve Gowda is relying on celestial prophecy—his astrologer has predicted that he will once again become the prime minister of the country—to back his ambitions, there's little that is left unsaid. More than anything else, Gowda is and will be best remembered for his dirty politicking, especially in Karnataka. And he must not forget that he has tough competition ahead with many suitors out in full force, who are trying their best to woo the electorate to be eligible to occupy the hot seat.

V.S. GANESHAN, Bangalore

Neighbour Trouble

Pakistan is yet again fraught with political uncertainty ("Advantage Zardari", September 8). What seems to have soured Asif Zardari and Nawaz Sharif's short-lived camaraderie is the fact that Zardari over-reached himself by unilaterally nominating himself for the presidency. Zardari has been riding high on his late wife Benazir Bhutto's popularity and is yet to prove his political acumen. However, the task of restoring normalcy in the trouble-torn nation should be the only priority, whoever comes to power.

NALINI VIJAYARAGHAVAN, on e-mail

Looking at the present political development in Pakistan, one wonders if the hard-won democracy after years of military rule is once again in the danger. It is being mismanaged due to the unbridled greed of some leaders and the needless ego clashes between the coalition partners—Nawaz Sharif and Asif Zardari—unwittingly once again paving way for military intervention.

K.V. RAGHURAM, on e-mail

Nehruvian Blunder

The root cause of the Kashmir imbroglio ("Villains of the Valley", September 1) can be traced back to the blunder committed by our first prime minister Jawaharlal Nehru. While Vallabhbhai Patel could unite 600 princely states, Nehru couldn't integrate even one state, Jammu and Kashmir. We are bearing the brunt of his folly now.

K. HEMANTH KUMAR D. PAI, Bangalore

WHEN THE RIVER SWALLOWED



The damage to life and property by the sudden change of course of the river Kosi has shown no signs of abating ("Rage of the River", September 8). Blaming Nepal for release of more water into Kosi that damaged the embankment might be politically right but an exercise in futility. The erosion of the embankment must have been going on for years and thanks to the careless maintenance of the structure, the danger of breakdown was waiting to happen.

D.B.N. MURTHY, Bangalore

To alleviate the suffering arising from the river's wrath, the governments, both at the Centre and in the state, politicians, other agencies, apart from the common people, should pitch in to help those rendered homeless, helpless and hopeless.

SEEMA SINGH, on e-mail

Instead of playing blame game, will the politicians use their time, energy, money and power for providing relief and rescue to the flood-hit people of Bihar?

RICHA SRIVASTAVA, Pune

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Years Ago in India Today

OCTOBER 16-31, 1978



Nafisa Ali

Femmes Fatale

It is a peculiar feature of all of Shyam Benegal's films that while they are packed with strong performances from the male leads, it is always the woman who steal the show. Benegal is one man who has casually, almost nonchalantly, steered every one of his new "finds" towards stardom. Shabana Azmi skyrocketed to award-winner status and her choice of roles on the commercial circuit on the basis of her performance in *Ankur*; Smita Patil graduated from virtual obscurity to instant fame, and now both Nafisa Ali and Dipti Naval appear to have made it before *Junoon* released. What is it that gives him this uncanny ability to create stars? One explanation is that while most of Hindi films revolve around their heroes, Benegal chooses to make his heroines the focus of attention. Others attribute it to his skillful handling of women. "I had never acted before but the way Shyam explained the role to me, I felt I could identify with the character," says Ali.

—Vir Sanghvi and Flora Zothanpari

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